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Hume and Daoism: In Defense of Communicable Aesthetic Sensibilities under Aesthetic Subjectivism

Introduction

Aesthetic subjectivism is the philosophical position that aesthetic values are derived in an individual non-objective way, as contrasted with aesthetic objectivists who posit aesthetic values within the object itself. I will show how the aesthetic theories of Hume and the Daoists allow for the ability to communicate and share aesthetic sensibilities and judgements within the framework of aesthetic subjectivism. In Hume's aesthetic theory, the value of art and other aesthetic forms is not contained wholly within either the object or the subject experiencing that object, but he instead adapts a position between subjectivism and objectivism that allows for individual experience while still allowing the possibility of sharing and critiquing these aesthetic forms. Similarly, the Daoist position of perspectivism provides an even more sufficient answer by allowing for the rich individuality of perspectives, but for these perspectives to still be shared and understood. Utilizing these two aesthetic theories, it is possible to rescue art from the alienation of subjectivism while still allowing dialogue and connection through aesthetic forms.

What is Aesthetic Subjectivism?

Aesthetic subjectivism can be broadly categorized as a set of philosophical positions on the nature of aesthetics that posit the aesthetic value of an object in the individual perceiving it. To the aesthetic subjectivist, a sunset or a painting can be said to be beautiful only because I myself find it to be beautiful. This can be distinguished from objective aesthetic positions that see aesthetic value within characteristics of the form itself, such as the composition of a painting or the smoothness of a sculpture. This distinction leads to

radically different understandings of the nature and purpose of art, and particularly the discussion and critique of aesthetics. To the objectivist, one could claim that a painting or song are objectively good or bad regardless of personal opinion based on intrinsic qualities of the piece itself. Whether you feel differently or are evoked toward a particular value judgement is irrelevant to the quality of the work itself. To the subjectivist, however, the sentiment itself is the source of aesthetic value, and thus no objective value judgements can be made. The opinion of the individual perceiving the form is the only source of this value and this value can change from individual to individual.

The Problem of Aesthetic Subjectivism

The primary issue with this individual basis of aesthetic subjectivism is that it leaves a significant question about whether aesthetic values can be shared at all. Because aesthetic subjectivism seems to create an unbridgeable gap in our ability to relate to each other through aesthetic sensibilities, can we evoke something shared? If not, is art valuable at all? These questions lead to a crisis of our current understanding of art and even our appreciation of natural beauty. To accept aesthetic subjectivism would be to radically restructure our understanding of aesthetics and the way we articulate our experience of them, giving up on the idea of art as a form of intelligible communication between people. In effect, we become isolated and alienated from each other, the language of art and beauty stripped from us as we become unable to share in each other's perceptions and experiences with any substantial tangibility. While this is not reason to necessarily reject aesthetic subjectivism in and of itself, it bears with it a critical question of whether there is a way in which we can rescue art and beauty from unintelligibility while retaining an appreciation for the wealth and variety of individual human experience.

Hume's Objective Judgements

The 18th century Scottish philosopher David Hume remains one of the most influential voices in the ongoing dialogue in philosophy about aesthetics. Hume was partially sympathetic to subjectivism in the sense that he did not posit beauty wholly in the object itself but did share with the objectivists his belief in the ability for objects to be fashioned to evoke specific responses and for valid judgements to be made about these objects. To Hume, beauty belongs to sentiment, the subjective experience of the individual, and thus beauty is not grounded in the objective.[1] Beauty is, to Hume, to the aesthetic state of the mind what virtues are to the moral state of the mind; a kind of emotional quality pertaining to an object or an action.[2] Although beauty exists within the individual through sentiment, it pertains to an object out in the world. Despite this subjective grounding for our experience of beauty, Hume, in contrast to other philosophers such as Immanuel Kant, remains steadfast in attempting to find some objective grounding for our taste. To Hume, this grounding comes through sentiment itself.[3] Although we may have differences in sentiment, it is possible for sentiment to pertain to its corresponding object with more or less accuracy. Just like color or shape are secondary qualities of an object, pertaining to but not revealing it entirely, there are secondary qualities of an object that are still objective, and our experience of these factual qualities can pertain more or less to its reality.[4] Thus, sentiment both allows for our subjective experience of objects while still providing grounds by which we might communicate and critique art and beauty with mutual grounding. The above argument can be formally represented as follows:

P1. If we are to communicate aesthetic sensibilities, there must be a shared grounding that pertains to the object being experienced, otherwise each person's experience bares no relation to another.

P2. Sentiment is present in everyone who experiences an object and can pertain more or less to the reality of the corresponding object.

C. Therefore, sentiment allows for us to communicate aesthetic sensibilities.

4. Gracyk, Theodore. "Hume's Aesthetics", The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy (Winter 2021 Edition). https://plato.stanford.edu/archives/win2021/entries/hume-aesthetics/, 3.1.

Daoist Perspectivism

Another answer to the question of shared aesthetic sensibilities comes from the Daoists. The Daoists shared a common form of aesthetic judgement through perspectivism. Perspectivism acknowledges the existence of perspective as the subjective experience of the world around us, not dissimilar to Hume's concept of sentiment. This grounds perspectivism in being compatible with a subjectivist understanding of beauty in which our aesthetic values are found within ourselves and not directly located in the external world. What makes perspectivism a viable candidate to answer the question of shared aesthetic sensibilities is the ability of perspective to be shared. This shared grounding of perspective by which we might relate to the experience of others lies in its relation to some factual properties of reality, such as our ability to look at the same mountain with different but communicable perspectives, which elevates it above the alienating realm of subjectivism. However, Daoism, in allowing for perspectives to be shared between people, allows for an even greater freedom than Hume's theory allows, as we can now not only communicate but actually share in the perspective of others within our own subjective experience. This argument from perspectivism can be formally represented as follows:

P1. If we are to communicate aesthetic sensibilities, there must be a shared grounding that pertains to the object being experienced, otherwise each person's experience bares no relation to another.

P2. Perspective exists in all beings and allows us to know about both our perspective as well as the perspective of other beings.

C. Therefore, perspective is sufficient grounding to allow for the communication of aesthetic sensibilities.

The Daoists are, however, quick to point out that one should not use their aesthetic judgements in an exclusionary or partial way, where one might favor the beautiful over the

5. Ames, Roger T. & Hall, David L. Dao De Jing: Making This Life Significant: A Philosophical Translation. Ballantine Books, 2003, 81.
6. Ames, Roger T. & Hall, David L. 2003, 80.

ugly or the strong over the weak, for example.[5] Because each distinction not only produces its opposite, but is necessary for its opposite to be what it truly is, to take a side is to exclude a necessary ontological category that is inseparably tied to its opposite.[6] Thus, in perspectivism we find the same epistemic realism found in Hume that allows for our aesthetic judgements to not only pertain to reality, but do so in a way that allows for dialogue between different sentiments or perspectives. But unlike Hume, perspectivism offers a different way to wisely discern how these judgements are used.

Objections

Within both Hume and the Daoists' theories, there lies a significant amount of ambiguity that leaves these theories open to critique. A valid objection to Hume's sentiment is that, because sentiment is entirely within the subject experiencing the object, there is no way in which we can truly tell whether someone's sentiment pertains to the reality of the object more than anyone else's. Failure in communication, as well as cultural and language differences, all throw a wrench into the idea of being able to weigh one sentiment against another, no matter how trained and impartial the judge. Likewise, if all we have to experience the world are our senses and reasoning, how do we establish what the true properties of an object are in order to say that one sentiment pertains more accurately than another? This objection also poses an issue for the concept of being able to fashion an object to evoke a particular response. This concept contains the assumption that not only do we have consistent sentiments, but that these sentiments are reproducible across multiple people. This entails that we share a similar enough phenomenological experience of the world to have some metric by which we might say one perspective pertains more truly to the reality of an object than another. While this does not outright discredit Hume's theory, it does raise the question of what basis we are making these implicit assumptions on.

This objection of our ability to bridge the subjective experiences between people also applies in a form to the subjective grounding of Daoist perspectivism. The Daoists,

5. Ames, Roger T. & Hall, David L. Dao De Jing: Making This Life Significant: A Philosophical Translation. Ballantine Books, 2003, 81.
6. Ames, Roger T. & Hall, David L. 2003, 80.

unlike Hume, can at least avoid this latter question of establishing true properties by allowing for perspectives to be shared.[7] It is perhaps sufficient enough that two people can share a perspective of an object to say that there is enough phenomenological grounding between individual perspectives to allow for aesthetic judgements. This, however, still leaves ambiguity in what manner we might establish that we are genuinely sharing the same perspective rather than a mutual misunderstanding of each other's subjective experience. Ultimately Hume and the Daoists would need to address these questions more clearly in order to have a sufficiently cohesive answer to the question of shared aesthetic sentiments.

Another possible objection to Hume's theory in particular is from a concern of ethics and artistic integrity. If we, in the example of Hume, allow for correct or incorrect aesthetic judgements, we open up the possibility of artistic elitism and a whole host of oppressive attitudes. For example, by crafting a work of art to evoke a particular sentiment, we open up the possibility of propaganda. How many times throughout history has the sentiment of national pride evoked through paintings, films, and music been used to justify war and atrocity? A less severe example is artistic and cultural elitism. While it could be argued that sentiment is common to all people, it is doubtful that there is not at least some influence on sentiment from culture and upbringing. Looking at the sheer diversity of artistic expression between places like Western Europe and Southeast Asia, for example, we can see that there is a vast array of aesthetic sensibilities that arise out of particular cultures and experiences. Without explicitly acknowledging this, it is easy for one culture to claim that the sentiment common to one culture is more accurate to a given object, and thus has a refined superiority, over another culture's sentiments. If we accept that Hume's theory of sentiment is correct, we have to accept its possible misuse as well.

7. Connolly, T. *Perspectivism as a Way of Knowing in the Zhuangzi*. Dao 10, 487–505, 2011, 491.
8. Gracyk, Theodore, 3.1.
9. Connolly, T. 495
10. Connolly, T. 493
11. Gracyk, Theodore, 4.

Counterargument

Though these objections are valid, I do not believe they spell the end of these theories to allow for aesthetic communication within subjectivism. To address the first objection that there is not a way to truly tell whether one person's experience pertains more to the reality of an object than another's, this firstly does not apply to art. If an artist creates a painting with the intention of evoking a certain sentiment or conveying the reality of some object in the world, then the basis by which we say someone's sentiment pertains to the object can be the degree to which their sentiment pertains to the sentiment the artist was looking to evoke. This is possible given Hume's theory that objects can be crafted to evoke certain sentiments.[8] In a similar manner, the Daoist perspectivists can easily evade this objection through their understanding that knowledge, even of oneself, is inseparable from perspective.[9] This, in effect, renders the objection a moot point, because to the perspectivist it is a useless question of whether your or my perspective pertains more truly to the reality of an object, but only that you or I have a particular perspective of that object at a particular time. This is explained in the *Zhuangzi* with the example of Lady Li, who humans regard as beautiful but who fish dart away from.[10] What matters is not that the human or fish perspective of Lady Li is more accurate to her actual beauty, but merely that humans regard her as beautiful and fish do not. More critically in separating perspectivism from pure subjectivism, we can know that humans regard her as beautiful and fish do not based on their individual perspectives.

With regards to the second objection about the ethical implications of Hume's position, Hume already addresses and accounts for these cultural differences in sentiment in understanding what would make a good aesthetic judge. The ideal critic, to Hume, must account for their cultural prejudice by putting themselves in the same position as the audience the work is intended for. In fact, it is a part of the five criteria of a true critic that they be "cleared of all prejudice."[11] This ability to see and understand the sentiment a work is intended to evoke allows for a kind of sympathy and understanding that is capable of

overcoming cultural bias and xenophobic inclinations. Likewise, such an ideal judge would be able to see through the manipulative evocation of sentiment in propaganda by understanding what sentiment is attempting to be evoked. Such a critic would see the sentiment of national pride and tribalism in the work and be able to deconstruct it. Thus, though Hume's aesthetic theory is ultimately normative, it is built on a sensitivity to the biases of each person, allowing them to empathetically adjust their own sentiments and not only find the aesthetic value in a work of art, but communicate it effectively.

Conclusion

The concept of aesthetic subjectivism has always entailed a variety of precarious dangers to our current understanding of art, beauty, and communication. The question of how we can avoid the equally dangerous pitfalls of believing entirely in aesthetic objectivism and retain the richness of individual experience while allowing for the possibility of communicating and sharing this experience is a critical one, and one that has been answered in a variety of different ways. Hume's concept of sentiment, by positing beauty in the subject as it pertains to qualities of the object, allows for subjective experiences of beauty while still allowing us to participate in dialogue and critique of these experiences. Daoist perspectivism, on the other hand, contains the same subject-object relationship of beauty that Hume does, while also allowing for the possibility of perspectives to be shared between individuals, opening an even more assured ability to communicate our aesthetic judgements and perspectives. What these schools of thought share is their ability to positively answer the question of whether it is possible to really share aesthetic sensibilities under aesthetic subjectivism and allow for both the richness of individual experience as well as the possibility of sharing that experience with others.

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2. Connolly, T. *Perspectivism as a Way of Knowing in the Zhuangzi*. Dao 10, 487–505, 2011.

3. Gracyk, Theodore. "Hume's Aesthetics", The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy (Winter 2021 Edition). https://plato.stanford.edu/archives/win2021/entries/hume-aesthetics/.
4. Kulenkampff, Jens. "The Objectivity of Taste: Hume and Kant." Noûs 24, no. 1 (03, 1990): 93-110. https://www.proquest.com/scholarly-journals/objectivity-taste-hume-kant/docview/42746219/se-2?accountid=14505.

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